

Live Shopping in the United States

A 2026 Search-Interest Report: the breakout, the platforms, and what is driving the trend

Alex Papageorgiou

2026-06-18

Abstract US live shopping has moved from a post-pandemic slump to a genuine breakout. After Meta retired its native live-shopping features in 2022-23, category search interest drifted lower and bottomed in mid-2024. It then inflected sharply: average monthly search interest rose roughly 49% in 2025, and the single largest spike on record lined up with the January 2025 US TikTok ban drama. This report rebuilds the live-shopping and live-selling search indices from a fresh pull of ~80,000 keywords (Google Ads Keyword Planner, June 2022 - May 2026, US only), re-examines every angle from the prior edition, and adds new ones: a platform-rotation view, the rise of category-native challengers, the trading-card-led vertical story, and an empirical look at trust (“is it legit?”) and the supply side.

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1 Executive summary

- **The category broke out in 2025.** Average monthly US search interest across a basket of 188+ live-shopping queries rose about **49% in 2025 versus 2024** (from roughly 5,840 to 8,680 indexed monthly searches), after two years of post-Meta decline that bottomed in mid-2024.
- **The single biggest spike is event-driven.** The index hit its peak in **January 2025** (more than 2.2x the June-2022 baseline), coinciding with the US TikTok ban drama and brief outage. Interest did not collapse afterwards - it settled onto a structurally higher plateau through 2025 and into 2026.
- **Whatnot is the defining company of this cycle.** Brand search for “whatnot” has grown roughly **7x in three years**; it is by far the fastest-growing live-shopping query. Whatnot reported **~\$6B+ GMV in 2025** (with ~\$8B in live GMV cited) and raised **\$225M at an \$11.5B valuation** in October 2025 - double its value at the start of the year.
- **A wave of category-native challengers has arrived.** Search interest is climbing for **Fanatics Live, eBay Live, and Palmstreet**, while **StockX Live** launches in summer 2026. The hype-driven drops model (NTWRK) is fading.
- **The supply side runs hotter than the demand side.** The **live-selling** index has more than doubled since 2022 (index ~246), and seller-intent queries - “how to sell on Whatnot”, “TikTok Shop seller center”, “whatnot seller fees” - are among the fastest growers. Sellers are a leading indicator.
- **Trust is the gating question.** “Is it legit?” searches scale with adoption. TikTok Shop legitimacy fears spiked after its 2023 US launch and then eased; **“is whatnot legit”** has climbed steadily and now leads, a natural by-product of mainstream growth.
- **Collectibles still lead, but the mix is broadening.** Trading cards / breaks dominate live-shopping vertical search (+135% over the window), while Whatnot’s own reporting shows beauty, electronics, jewelry and women’s fashion as its fastest-growing GMV categories.

2 Introduction and method

Live shopping - real-time, video-led commerce where a host sells to a live audience that can buy, bid, and chat in the moment - has been “about to happen” in the US for years. In China it is mature (an estimated ~60% of e-commerce involves live formats); in the US it has hovered around ~5% of e-commerce. The question for 2026 is whether the US has finally turned the corner. Search behaviour is a useful, unbiased leading signal: it captures demand before it shows up in GMV, and it captures supply-side intent (people learning to sell) before sellers are onboarded.

2.1 What we measure

We track **search interest** - how often Americans search Google for live-shopping-related terms - as a proxy for category attention. Two indices are built:

- **Live Shopping index** - consumer-facing queries (e.g. *live shopping*, *tiktok live shopping*, *whatnot live shopping*, *live commerce*).
- **Live Selling index** - seller-oriented queries (e.g. *live selling*, *how to sell on whatnot*, *tiktok live selling*).

2.2 How the data is built

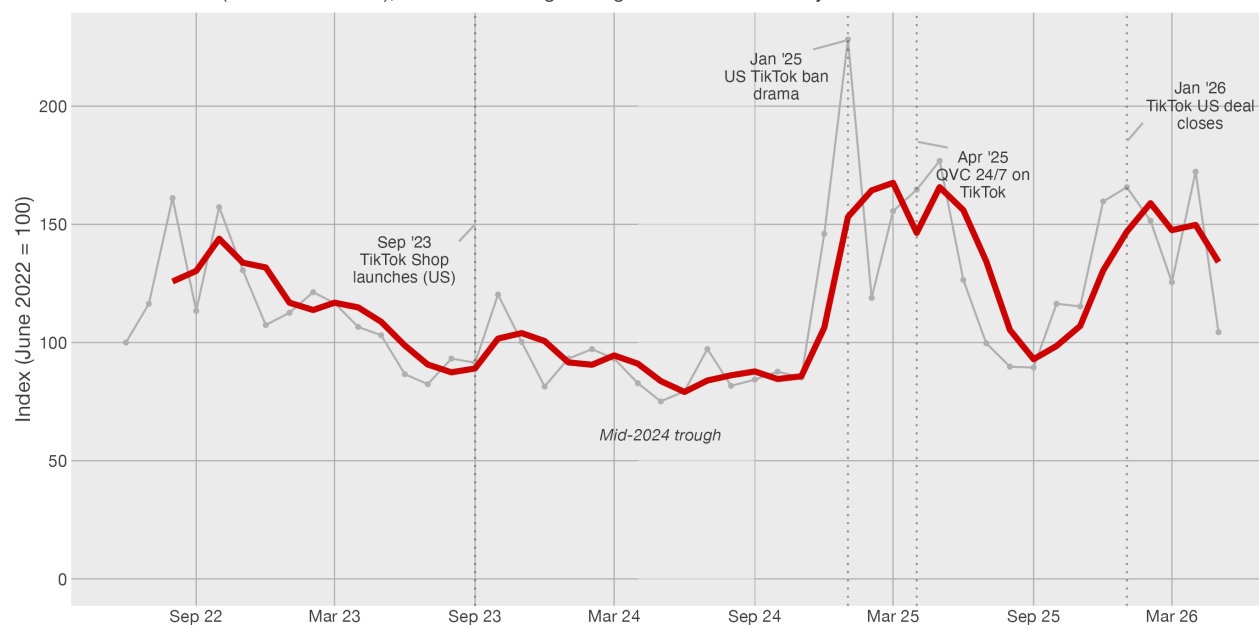
Starting from ~7,700 curated seed terms (the prior study’s seeds plus new 2026 seeds for emerging platforms and verticals), we expanded them via the Google Ads Keyword Planner API into a universe of **~257,000 raw keyword ideas**, de-duplicated to **~79,000 unique keywords** with complete monthly histories. The window is **June 2022 - May 2026 (48 months), US and English only**. Each index sums monthly search volume across its keyword basket and is normalized so the first month = 100. Charts show a 3-month moving average to suppress month-to-month noise; the thin grey line is the raw monthly series.

A note on this edition: unlike the prior study, we **do not reuse any historical search volumes** - every number here comes from one fresh pull, so the series is internally consistent. Known bot-inflated terms are excluded. This is a US-only report; international markets are out of scope by design.

3 The headline: a trough, then a breakout

US live shopping search interest: from post-Meta slump to a 2025 breakout

Search-interest index (June 2022 = 100), 3-month moving average. Thin line = monthly values.



Source: Google Ads Keyword Planner API (US, English), June 2022 - May 2026. Data retrieved June 2026. Index = normalized U.S. search volume, first month = 100.

Figure 1: US live-shopping search interest, June 2022 - May 2026. The category declined after Meta exited live shopping, bottomed in mid-2024, then broke out - peaking around the January 2025 US TikTok ban drama and holding a higher plateau since.

The shape of Figure 1 is the story of the whole report. Three phases stand out:

1. **Drift and decline (2022 - mid-2024).** Meta's retreat from native live shopping - Facebook live shopping ended in 2022, Instagram's in early 2023 - removed the most visible on-ramp for mainstream US consumers. Interest drifted down and reached its **lowest point in mid-2024**.
2. **The inflection (late 2024 - early 2025).** Interest turned up sharply in Q4 2024 and **peaked in January 2025**, when the US TikTok ban saga and brief app-store outage put social commerce on every front page. This is the clearest example in the data of an external event moving the category.
3. **A higher plateau (2025 - 2026).** Crucially, interest did **not** revert to the 2024 trough. It settled onto a visibly higher band, with seasonal peaks (holiday quarters) now towering over the old baseline. Average monthly interest in 2025 was about **49% above 2024**.

The contrast with the prior edition is instructive. A year ago the story was "recovery underway"; with a full extra year of data, it now reads as a **regime change** - the floor has moved up, not just the ceiling.

4 What drove the inflection

Search interest rarely moves on its own. Overlaying the index against the live-shopping news cycle, a handful of events align with the turns in Figure 1:

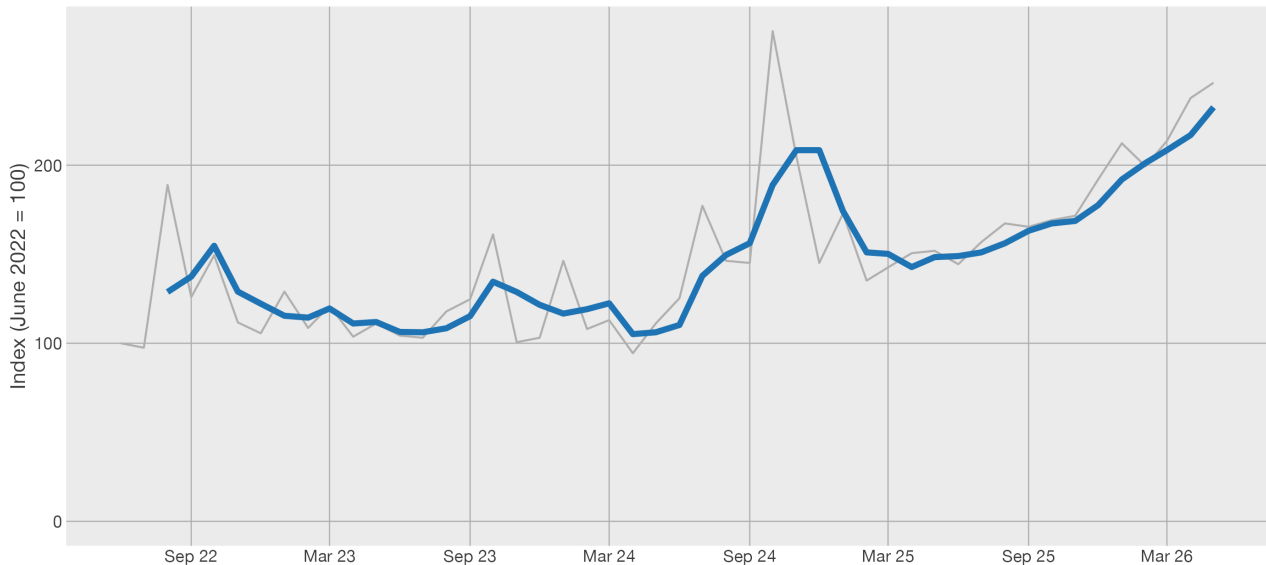
When	Event	Effect on search
Aug 2022 / Mar 2023	Meta ends Facebook / Instagram live shopping	Removes a mainstream on-ramp; interest drifts down
Sep 2023	TikTok Shop launches in the US	Re-seeds the category; stabilizes interest
Jan 2025	US TikTok ban drama + brief outage	Largest single spike on record
Feb 2025	Qurate rebrands to QVC Group (“live social shopping company”)	Legacy TV shopping repositions around live
Apr 2025	QVC launches a 24/7 live channel on TikTok	Reinforces the TikTok-as-storefront narrative
Oct 2025	Whatnot raises \$225M at an \$11.5B valuation	Validates the category for investors and press
Jan 2026	TikTok US “USDS” joint venture closes (ban resolved)	Removes the existential overhang for the biggest social storefront

The throughline is **TikTok**. Its 2023 launch re-seeded US live commerce; its 2025 political drama supplied the demand shock; and the January 2026 ownership resolution (ByteDance below 20%, an Oracle / Silver Lake / MGX-led group holding the majority) removed the tail risk that had hung over the single largest social storefront. TikTok Shop’s own scale underlines why this matters: **US GMV grew from ~\$9B in 2024 to ~\$15B in 2025**, and the number of US sellers exploded from ~4,450 in mid-2023 to ~475,000 by mid-2025.

5 The supply side leads: live selling

The supply side runs hotter: **live selling** interest has more than doubled

Seller-oriented query index (June 2022 = 100), 3-month moving average. Sellers lead the category.



Source: Google Ads Keyword Planner API (US, English), June 2022 - May 2026. Data retrieved June 2026. Index = normalized U.S. search volume, first month = 100.

Figure 2: The live-selling (seller-intent) index has more than doubled since 2022, outpacing the consumer-facing live-shopping index.

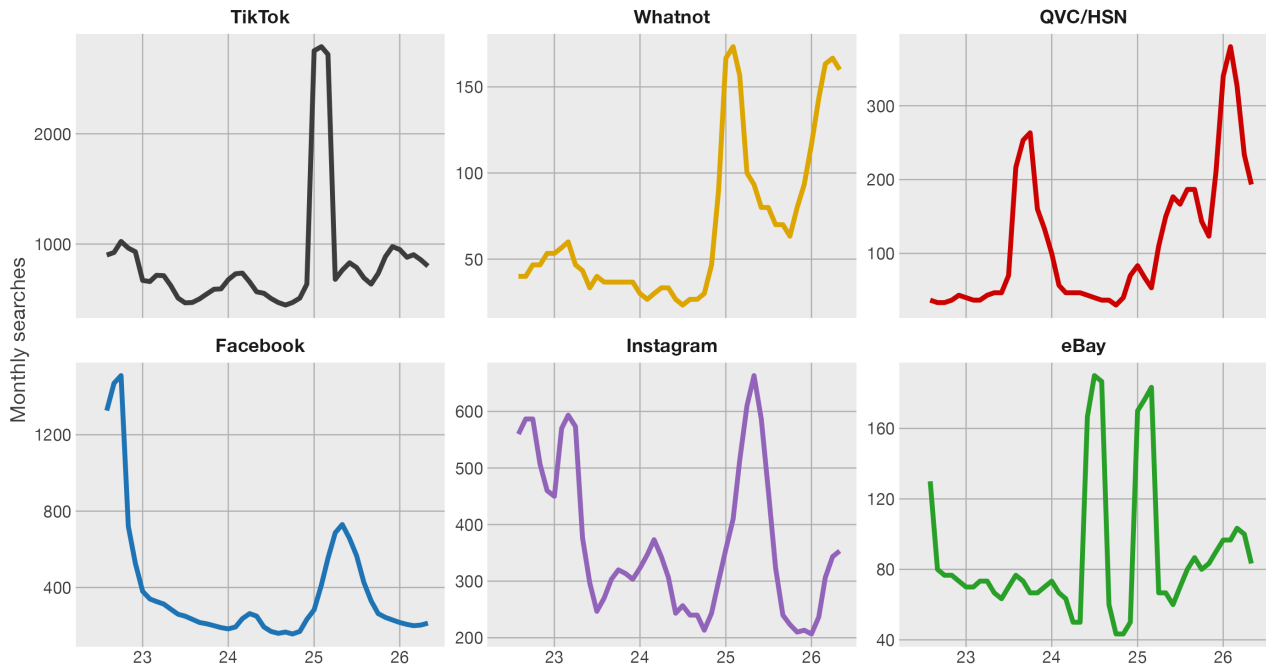
One of the most reliable patterns in the data is that **sellers move first**. The live-selling index (Figure 2) has more than doubled since 2022 and sits well above the consumer index in relative terms. Seller-intent queries are also disproportionately represented among the fastest-growing terms overall: *how to sell on whatnot*, *tiktok shop seller center*, *tiktok shop affiliate program*, *whatnot seller fees*.

Why this matters: live commerce is a two-sided market, and supply is the constraint. A surge in people learning **how to sell** is a leading indicator that the next wave of inventory, hosts, and content is being created now - which tends to pull consumer interest up behind it. The signal-to-noise on the selling side is also higher: nobody idly searches "whatnot seller fees" - that is someone with a business plan.

6 Platform rotation

Platform rotation in live-shopping search: **Whatnot** and **QVC/HSN** rise as Meta fades

Monthly US search interest in '[platform] live shopping'-type queries, 3-month moving average.



Source: Google Ads Keyword Planner API (US, English), June 2022 - May 2026. Data retrieved June 2026. Index = normalized U.S. search volume, first month = 100.

Figure 3: Live-shopping search interest by platform (queries of the form “[platform] live shopping”), 3-month moving average. Whatnot and QVC/HSN trend up; Meta’s surfaces fade; TikTok dominates and spikes with the 2025 news cycle.

When we slice live-shopping queries by the platform named in them (Figure 3), a clear **rotation** appears:

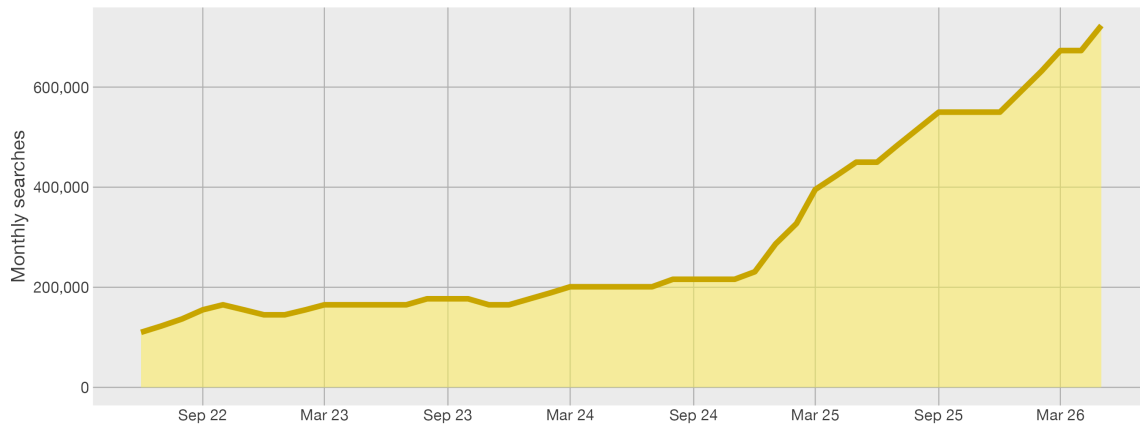
- **TikTok** dominates in absolute terms and shows the January 2025 spike most violently - it is the lightning rod for category attention.
- **Whatnot** and **QVC/HSN** are the two clear up-and-to-the-right trends. QVC/HSN is the more surprising of the two: a 40-year-old TV-shopping incumbent is being **re-discovered through a live-social lens**, helped by its 2025 rebrand and its 24/7 TikTok channel.
- **Facebook** and **Instagram** fade steadily - the long tail of Meta’s 2022-23 exit.
- **eBay** is volatile but present, buoyed by eBay Live’s expansion into collectibles, watches, and handbags.

The strategic read: the category is **not** consolidating onto one app. TikTok is the top-of-funnel attention engine, Whatnot is the category-native destination, and QVC/HSN shows that incumbents can re-platform onto live-social rather than be displaced by it - even as the parent company restructures (QVC Group filed a prepackaged Chapter 11 in April 2026 to cut debt while pursuing its live-social “WIN” strategy).

7 Whatnot: the defining company of the cycle

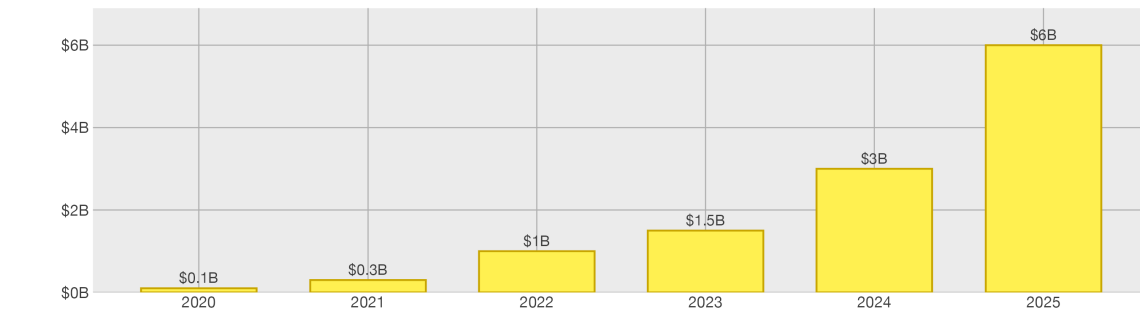
Brand search for Whatnot has grown ~7x in three years

US monthly searches for “whatnot”, 3-month moving average.



Whatnot gross merchandise value (GMV)

Estimated annual GMV from public reporting. 2025 ~ \$6B+ (\$8B live GMV cited); valued at \$11.5B (Oct 2025).



Whatnot GMV are estimates from public announcements. Search: Google Ads Keyword Planner API.

Figure 4: Top: US brand search for “whatnot” has grown roughly 7x since 2022. Bottom: estimated Whatnot GMV, ~\$0.1B (2020) to ~\$6B+ (2025).

If 2025 has a protagonist, it is **Whatnot**. By every angle in the data it is the strongest trend in live shopping:

- **Search:** brand interest is up ~7x in three years (Figure 4, top) and “whatnot” is the single fastest-growing live-shopping query by a wide margin.
- **GMV:** roughly **\$0.1B (2020) -> \$1.5B (2023) -> \$3B (2024) -> \$6B+ (2025)**, with the company citing ~\$8B in live GMV and revenue approaching \$1B. Growth has been close to 2x a year.
- **Capital:** a **\$225M round at an \$11.5B valuation** in October 2025 (DST Global and CapitalG leading; Sequoia, a16z, Greycroft, BOND participating), roughly double the start-of-year mark; ~\$968M raised since 2019.
- **Engagement:** ~80-95 minutes per active user per day, >80% month-over-month retention, and new buyers up ~285% year on year. It ranked the **#1 shopping app in both the US and UK** in 2025 and did **\$100M+ in live sales on Black Friday alone**.

A year ago the open question was whether Whatnot could keep doubling. The 2025 data says yes: it both **doubled GMV and re-rated in the private markets**, while broadening from its collectibles roots into 140+ categories. The risk is no longer demand - it is whether supply (sellers, moderation, fulfillment, trust) can scale with it.

8 The challengers

Beyond Whatnot: a wave of **category-native** live-shopping challengers

US monthly search interest, 3-month moving average. Fanatics Live, eBay Live and Palmstreet climb; NTRK's drop-hype fades.

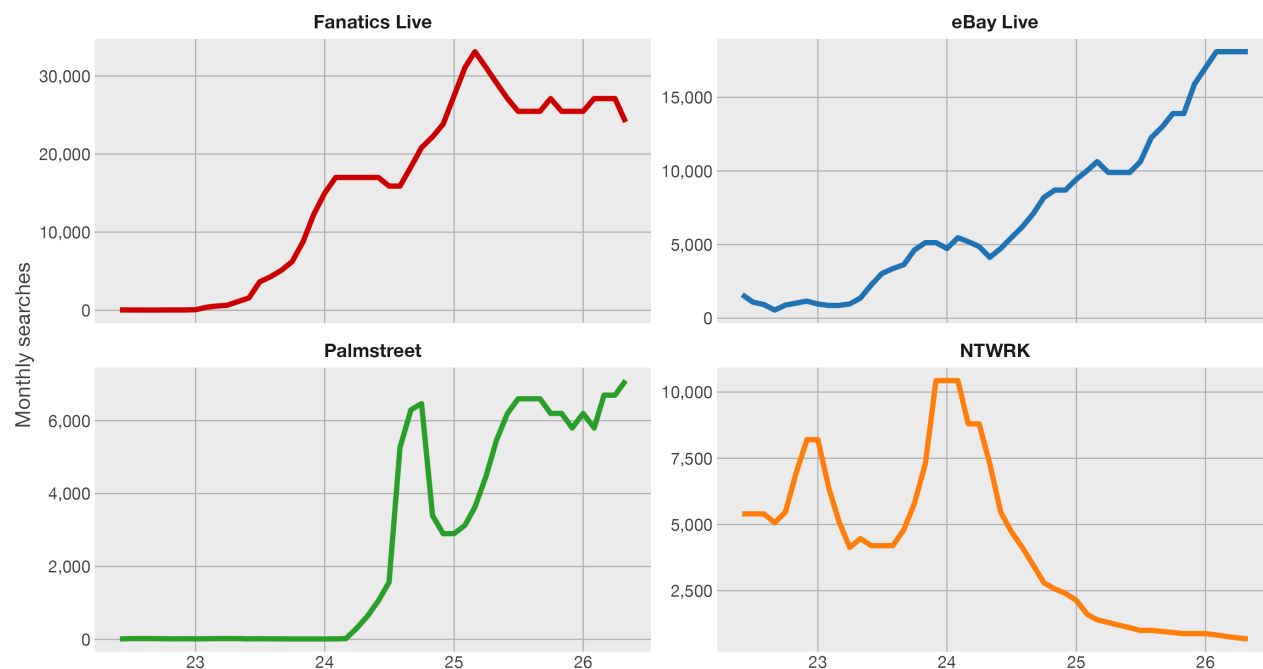


Figure 5: Category-native live-shopping challengers. Fanatics Live, eBay Live and Palmstreet are climbing; NTRK's drops-driven model is fading.

Whatnot is not alone. A cohort of **category-native** platforms is gaining search traction (Figure 5), each owning a vertical rather than chasing “everything live”:

- **Fanatics Live** - trading cards and sports collectibles, leveraging Fanatics' licensing and “breaks” culture. The clearest challenger uptrend.
- **eBay Live** - cards and collectibles first, now luxury watches, handbags and fashion; expanding to Germany and Canada in 2026.
- **Palmstreet** - a genuine surprise: a niche live marketplace (plants, ceramics, niche collectibles) breaking out from near zero in 2024 to a durable base.
- **StockX Live** - announced for **summer 2026** (sneakers, apparel, cards, vintage); too new to register in search yet, but one to watch.
- **NTRK** - the celebrity/drops model has **faded** from its 2023-24 peak, a reminder that hype-driven formats are harder to sustain than community-driven ones.

The pattern is telling: the winners are **community-and-category-native** (Whatnot, Fanatics, Palmstreet), not generic “live video + cart” tools. Owning a passionate vertical beats owning a feature.

9 What is growing fastest

Fastest-growing live-shopping queries are about **Whatnot**, **challengers**, selling & **trust**

Monthly-search growth slope (linear trend on 3-mo avg), live-shopping-relevant queries.

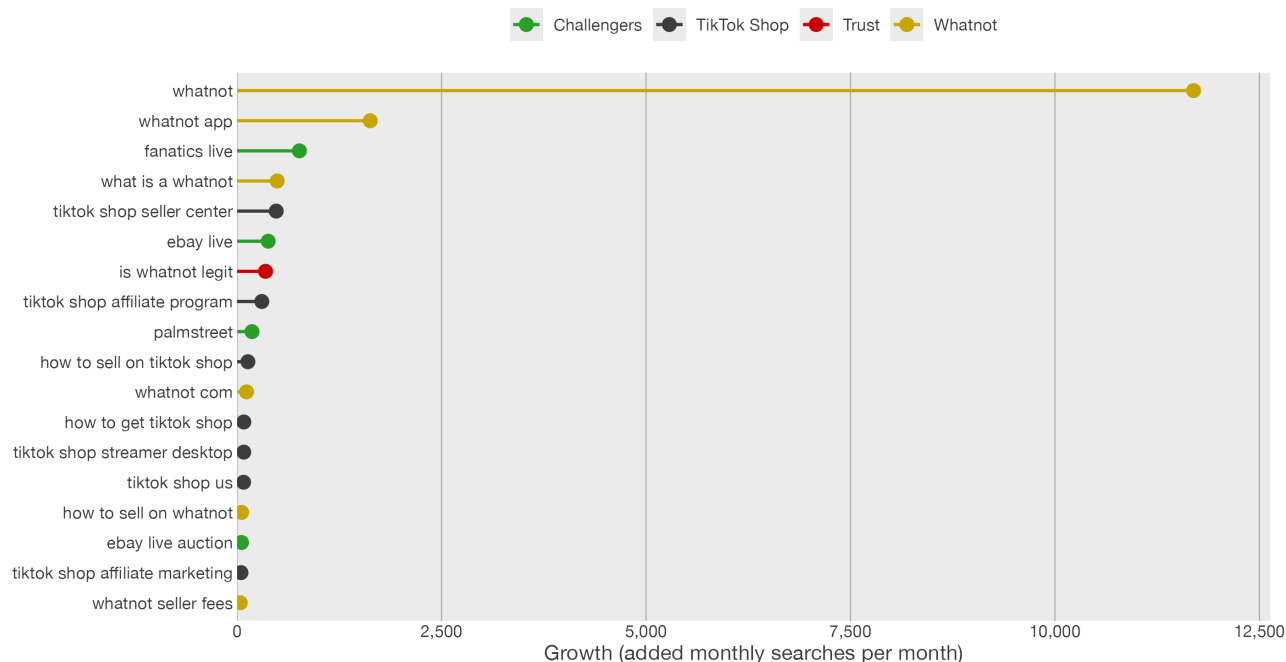


Figure 6: The fastest-growing live-shopping queries, ranked by trend slope (added monthly searches per month). Whatnot, the challengers, seller-intent and trust queries dominate.

Ranking every live-shopping-relevant query by its growth slope (Figure 6) is a compact summary of the whole report. Four themes own the leaderboard:

1. **Whatnot** - the brand and its long tail (*whatnot app*, *what is a whatnot*, *whatnot com*, *whatnot seller fees*).
2. **Challengers** - *fanatics live*, *ebay live*, *palmstreet*, *ebay live auction*.
3. **Selling** - *tiktok shop seller center*, *how to sell on tiktok shop*, *tiktok shop affiliate program*, *how to sell on whatnot*.
4. **Trust** - *is whatnot legit*, *is whatnot app legit*.

That trust queries grow alongside brand and seller queries is the single most interesting cross-cutting finding, and it deserves its own section.

10 Trust: “is it legit?”

Trust is the gating question: “is it **legit**?” searches climb with adoption

US monthly searches for legitimacy queries, 3-month moving average. Inline labels at right.

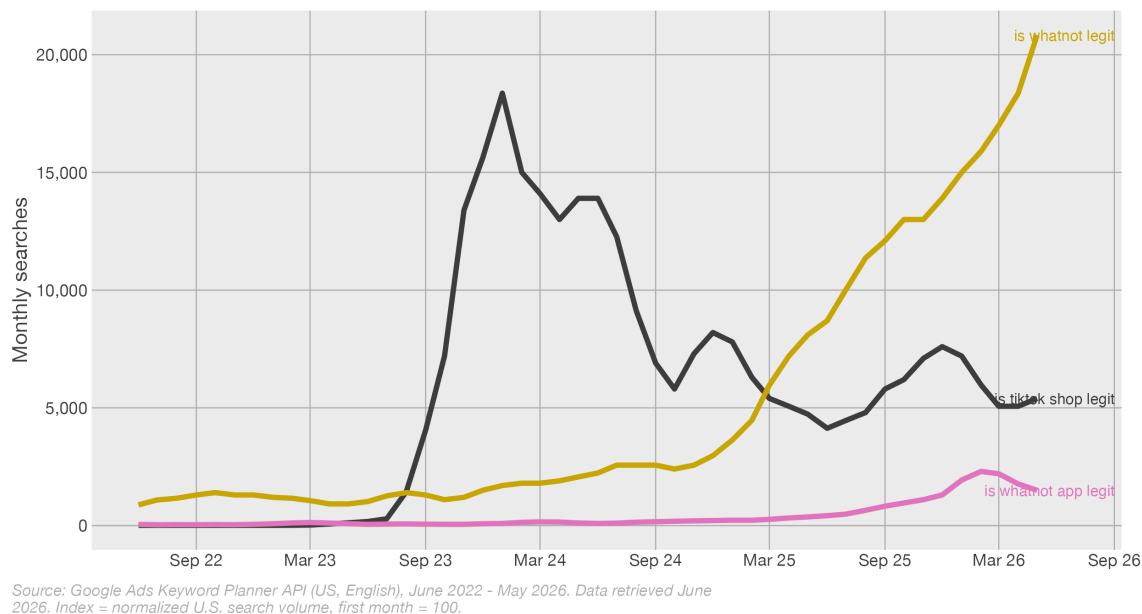


Figure 7: Legitimacy queries scale with adoption. TikTok Shop legitimacy fears spiked after its 2023 US launch then eased; “is whatnot legit” has climbed steadily and now leads.

As live shopping goes mainstream, consumers do something very human: they ask whether they can trust it. Figure 7 tracks legitimacy queries:

- **“Is TikTok Shop legit”** spiked dramatically after the 2023 US launch - a wave of skepticism about a new, unfamiliar, algorithm-driven storefront - then eased as the format became familiar.
- **“Is Whatnot legit”** has climbed steadily and now **leads**, which is exactly what you would expect from a platform moving from niche to mainstream: more new buyers means more first-time due-diligence searches.

The qualitative concerns behind these searches are consistent across platforms: counterfeit or low-quality goods, items that never arrive (often small international sellers), and refund friction. The practical implication for platforms is that **trust infrastructure - verified sellers, buyer protection, transparent fees, dispute resolution - is now a growth lever, not a compliance cost**. Trust questions are not a sign of trouble; they are a sign of scale. But the platform that answers them best will convert the most skeptics.

11 Vertical breakouts

Two complementary views of “what sells live” emerge from the data.

On the search side, collectibles still lead. Within a live-shopping context, **trading cards and “breaks”** dominate vertical search interest and grew ~135% over the window - the single clearest vertical signal. This is the cultural engine that built Whatnot, Fanatics Live and eBay Live, and it remains the gateway drug into live shopping.

On the GMV side, the mix is broadening fast. Whatnot’s own 2025 reporting shows its fastest-growing categories by GMV are now well beyond collectibles:

Category	Whatnot GMV growth (2025, YoY)
Beauty	+791%

Category	Whatnot GMV growth (2025, YoY)
Electronics	+444%
Jewelry	+259%
Women's fashion	+223%

The reconciliation between the two views is the insight: **collectibles are the top of the funnel** (they bring passionate, daily-active users in), while **beauty, fashion, electronics and jewelry are where the dollars are scaling**. A platform that converts a card collector into a beauty or fashion buyer captures both the engagement and the basket.

12 Live auctions: a parallel format

A distinct but related behaviour runs underneath the headline trend: **live auctions**. Bid-based, time-pressured, collectibles-led selling (cards, sneakers, coins, comics, Funko) shows up in queries like *ebay live auction* and underpins much of Whatnot's and Fanatics Live's engagement. Auctions carry a different psychology from fixed-price live shopping - higher intensity, social competition, and a "win" payoff - and they map onto the same collectibles verticals that lead the category. StockX Live's 2026 entry is explicitly auction-and-drop flavoured. Auctions are worth tracking as a leading indicator: they tend to attract the most engaged users first.

13 Outlook and implications

The base case for 2026-27 is continued, structurally higher growth. The category cleared three overhangs at once: Meta's exit is fully digested, TikTok's ownership question is resolved, and a category-native champion (Whatnot) has both the GMV trajectory and the capital to keep expanding. Search interest sits on a higher plateau, the supply side is heating up faster than the demand side, and incumbents (QVC/HSN) are re-platforming rather than disappearing.

What to watch:

- **Can supply scale with trust intact?** The gating risk is no longer demand - it is whether platforms can grow sellers and inventory without letting counterfeits, non-delivery and refund friction erode the trust that adoption depends on.
- **Does the vertical mix keep broadening?** If beauty, fashion and electronics keep compounding the way collectibles did, live shopping graduates from a hobbyist niche to a mainstream retail channel.
- **TikTok Shop's live mix.** Livestreams are still a minority of TikTok Shop GMV (~14% in 2025 vs ~10% in 2024); if that share climbs now that the ownership question is settled, it would meaningfully lift the whole category.
- **The challengers' lanes.** Fanatics Live, eBay Live, Palmstreet and the incoming StockX Live suggest the future is a **federation of category-native live marketplaces**, not a single winner-take-all app.

The one-line takeaway: **US live shopping in 2026 is no longer a question of "if" - it is a question of how fast supply and trust can scale to meet demand that has already inflected.**

14 Appendix

14.1 Methodology details

- **Source:** Google Ads Keyword Planner API (keyword ideas + historical metrics), US (location 2840), English (language 1000).
- **Window:** June 2022 - May 2026 (48 months), retrieved June 2026. The Keyword Planner returns a rolling 48-month window; this edition uses only that fresh window and does not splice in older data.
- **Seeds -> universe:** ~7,700 curated seeds (prior study + 2026 additions) expanded to ~257,000 raw ideas, de-duplicated (including metric-identical keyword collisions) to ~79,000 unique keywords with complete 48-month histories.
- **Indices:** the Live Shopping basket matches *live shop*, *livestream shop*, *live commerce*, *live stream shop*, *livestream commerce*; the Live Selling basket matches *live sell*. Monthly volumes are summed across the basket and normalized so the first month = 100. Charts use a right-aligned 3-month moving average.
- **Trend stats:** per-keyword 3-month rolling average and an OLS linear trend (slope, R-squared) on keywords with a meaningful signal (max monthly volume > 20, fewer than 47 zero months).
- **Exclusions:** known bot-inflated terms are removed; international markets are out of scope.

14.2 Caveats

Search interest is a proxy for attention, not a direct measure of sales. Absolute Keyword Planner volumes are bucketed and should be read as orders of magnitude. GMV, funding and event figures are drawn from public reporting and company statements (see sources) and are estimates.

14.3 Selected sources

- **Whatnot** (GMV, valuation, categories, engagement): Business of Fashion; Digital Commerce 360; TechFunding News; Sacra; Fortune; Marketplace Pulse; FashionNetwork; Whatnot 2026 trends.
- **TikTok Shop** (US GMV, sellers, live mix): Momentum Works / The Low Down; FastMoss; Statista; Marketing LTB.
- **TikTok ownership deal** (Jan 2026 USDS joint venture): TechCrunch; Marketplace; Retail TouchPoints.
- **QVC Group** (rebrand, TikTok channel, Chapter 11): QVC Group SEC 8-K filings (CIK 1355096).
- **Challengers** (StockX Live, Fanatics Live, eBay Live, Popshop/CommentSold): PR Newswire; WWD; CNBC; Value Added Resource; Retail Dive.
- **Market size / adoption / trust:** GetStream; Grand View Research; Statista; eMarketer; consumer-trust coverage (Surfshark, TrustDALE, Avast, University of Kentucky ITS).

Reproducible code and data pipeline: project repository (pipeline-2026/, report-2026/).